

Making Your First Open Source Contribution

So you want to contribute to open source



Intro



Agenda



Intro

This bit

Find your niche

The best contributions overlap with your passions

Not all contributions are code

There's more to open source than writing code

(Before) Opening your first pull request

Increasing the chances of your PR being merged

Using AI agents responsibly

AI != community



Who am I?

Martin Costello

Staff Software Engineer @ Grafana Labs

- I spend 99% of my time on non-Grafana Labs code
- OpenTelemetry .NET SDK maintainer
- Microsoft MVP for .NET
- My first GitHub pull request was in 2013

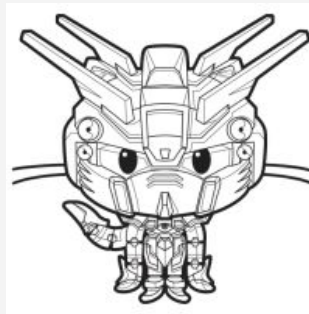


@martincostello



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Contributions to



My first PR

 Conversation 8

 Commits 3

 Checks 0

 Files changed 2



Martin Costello (martincostello) commented on Jul 29, 2013

Contributor ...

Proposed change to fix Issue 491. The wording isn't necessarily exactly what the message should say, but it's a suggestion. Other than rewording the message, I don't think any other changes would be needed.

I've avoided having the unit test assert on the exact URL of the message.

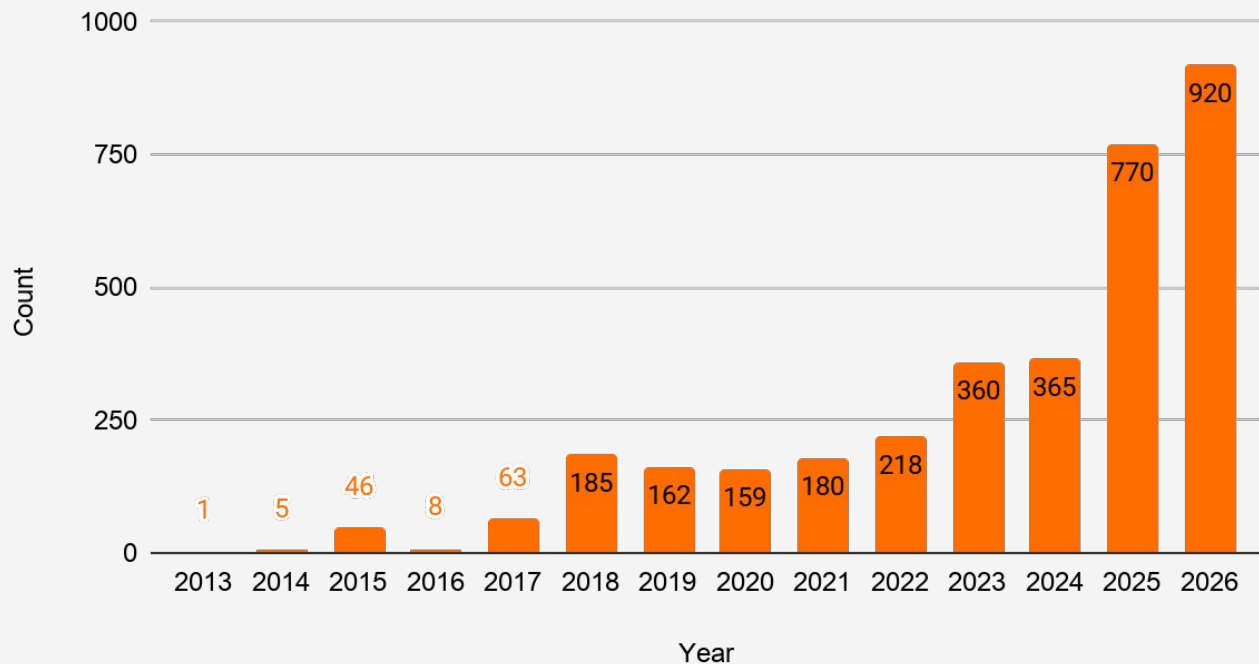


[Glimpse/Glimpse#493](https://github.com/Glimpse/Glimpse/pull/493)



Start small

Pull requests by year



Via <https://github.com/martincostello/github-pr-stats>



Find your niche



Where do I start?

- What are your skills?
- What interests you?
- What are your hobbies?
- What is your job?



Quick ways to start

- Found a bug? Fix it!
- Spotted a user-facing typo? Fix it!
- Confusing documentation? Raise an issue
- Localisation for a language other than English



Things to avoid

- Big changes
- Arbitrary refactoring
- A way to learn a new language



**Not all contributions are
code**



Non-feature contributions often overlooked

- Issue triage
- Missing documentation
- Improving test coverage
- Fixing flaky tests
- Automating a manual process



(Before) Opening your first pull request



Before starting to contribute

- Have a goal
- Don't feel obligated
- Do you have the (free) time?
- Does your employer let you?
- Can you sign a CLA?



Contributor Licence Agreements (CLAs)



cla-assistant Bot commented 1 hour ago



CLA not signed yet

Thank you for your submission! We really appreciate it. Like many open source projects, we ask that you sign our [Contributor License Agreement](#) before we can accept your contribution.

You have signed the CLA already but the status is still pending? Let us [recheck](#) it.



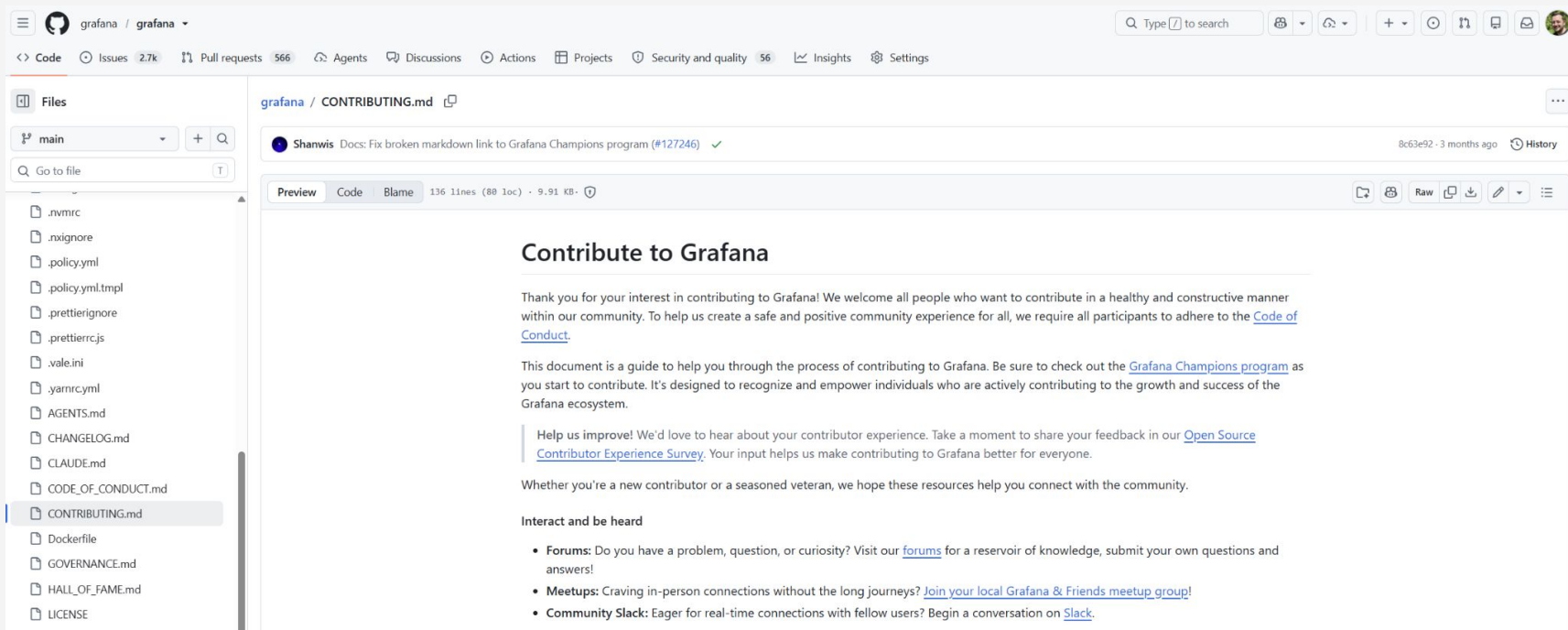
Once you've found a repo

- Is the repo active?
- Does it use an appropriate licence?
- Read the contribution guide



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Once you've found a repo



The screenshot shows the GitHub interface for the Grafana repository. The left sidebar displays the file tree with 'CONTRIBUTING.md' selected. The main content area shows the 'CONTRIBUTING.md' file, which is a guide for new contributors. The file is titled 'Contribute to Grafana' and includes sections on how to contribute, a feedback survey, and community resources. The file is 136 lines long, 88 loc, and 9.91 KB. The commit history shows a recent commit by Shanwis titled 'Docs: Fix broken markdown link to Grafana Champions program (#127246)'.

grafana / grafana

Code Issues 2.7k Pull requests 566 Agents Discussions Actions Projects Security and quality 56 Insights Settings

Files

main

Go to file

.nvmrc
.nxignore
.policy.yml
.policy.yml.tpl
.prettiignore
.prettierrc.js
.vale.ini
.yamrc.yml
AGENTS.md
CHANGELOG.md
CLAUDE.md
CODE_OF_CONDUCT.md
CONTRIBUTING.md
Dockerfile
GOVERNANCE.md
HALL_OF_FAME.md
LICENSE

grafana / CONTRIBUTING.md

Shanwis Docs: Fix broken markdown link to Grafana Champions program (#127246) ✓

8c63e92 · 3 months ago History

Preview Code Blame 136 lines (88 loc) · 9.91 KB

Contribute to Grafana

Thank you for your interest in contributing to Grafana! We welcome all people who want to contribute in a healthy and constructive manner within our community. To help us create a safe and positive community experience for all, we require all participants to adhere to the [Code of Conduct](#).

This document is a guide to help you through the process of contributing to Grafana. Be sure to check out the [Grafana Champions program](#) as you start to contribute. It's designed to recognize and empower individuals who are actively contributing to the growth and success of the Grafana ecosystem.

Help us improve! We'd love to hear about your contributor experience. Take a moment to share your feedback in our [Open Source Contributor Experience Survey](#). Your input helps us make contributing to Grafana better for everyone.

Whether you're a new contributor or a seasoned veteran, we hope these resources help you connect with the community.

Interact and be heard

- **Forums:** Do you have a problem, question, or curiosity? Visit our [forums](#) for a reservoir of knowledge, submit your own questions and answers!
- **Meetups:** Craving in-person connections without the long journeys? [Join your local Grafana & Friends meetup group!](#)
- **Community Slack:** Eager for real-time connections with fellow users? Begin a conversation on [Slack](#).



Finding an issue

- Check for *help wanted* labels
- Don't duplicate effort
- Signal your intentions
- Don't wait to be asked to participate
- Start small



Before opening a PR

- Read the contribution guide
- Follow existing conventions
- Keep the scope focused
- Add tests where relevant
- Perform a self-review



After opening a PR

- Be patient
- Be prepared for feedback
- Don't take things personally
- Don't give up



After your PR is merged

- Don't chase
- Be prepared to make mistakes
- Don't feel obligated to fix any bugs



A good example

Notifications: Don't stop sending emails after the first failure # [REDACTED] Code ▾

Merged [REDACTED] merged 1 commit into grafana:main from [REDACTED]:fix-smtp-partial-failure 3 days ago

Conversation 4 Commits 1 Checks 157 **Files changed 2** +56 -3

[REDACTED] commented on Aug 2 • edited ▾ Contributor ⋮

Regressed in [#90559](#), originally fixed in [#16881](#).

What is this feature?

Fixes email notifications so one failed address doesn't stop the rest of the list. The send loop in `pkg/services/notifications/smtp.go` returned on the first error, skipping every remaining recipient. It now attempts all messages and returns the errors joined.

Why do we need this feature?

One stale address in an email contact point silently blocks everyone after it from getting alert emails. This was fixed in [#16881](#) but regressed in [#90559](#) during a tracing refactor.

Who is this feature for?

Anyone using email contact points with multiple addresses.

Which issue(s) does this PR fix?:

Fixes [#129917](#)

Special notes for your reviewer:

The regression test fails on main (count 1 instead of 2) and passes with the fix.

Please check that:

- ☒ It works as expected from a user's perspective.
- ☒ If this is a pre-GA feature, it is behind a feature toggle.
- ☒ The docs are updated, and if this is a [notable improvement](#), it's added to our [What's New](#) doc.

Reviewers

Copilot Lite ▾

Assignees

No one—[assign yourself](#)

Labels

[area/backend](#) [pr/external](#)

Projects

None yet

Milestone

13.3.x

Development

Successfully merging this pull request may close these issues.

☒ [Single sign-on](#) to see issues within the grafana-knowledge organization.

☒ [Email notification stops after first failed address \(regr...](#)

Notifications Customize



A less good example

docs: fix grammar issues in README.md # [REDACTED] 

 Closed [REDACTED] wants to merge 1 commit into grafana:main from [REDACTED]:main 

 Conversation 2  Commits 1  Checks 5  Files changed 22284 +4,906,676 

[REDACTED] commented on Aug 14 First-time contributor ...

What changed

Fixed grammar/typo issues in the README.

Why

Minor documentation cleanup.

How verified

Visual inspection of the diff.



Reviewers

-  docs-grafana  
-  Grafana Catalog  
-  dashboards-squad  
-  alerting-squad  



Using AI agents responsibly



Using AI agents responsibly

- Don't farm for reputation
- Don't fall into the "slop" trap
- Prioritise human connection
- Check the repo's AI acceptance



“Claude said...”

Niklas Gruhn - “*Don’t be a meat proxy*”



Using AI agents responsibly

- Can you confidently explain the changes?
- Own the content
- Don't conceal AI usage — we can usually tell
- Don't blindly address AI review comments



An example of an AI “CAPTCHA”



martincostello commented on Aug 10

Member



- ☒ I have read and followed the [Contributing](#) docs, especially the "First-time contributing?" section.
- ☐ This PR has content that I did not fully write myself.
 - ☐ I used AI and I have read and followed the [Generative AI Contribution Policy](#).
- ☒ I have the experience and knowledge necessary to understand, review, and validate all content in this PR.

Add blog post on dual exporting metrics to OTLP and Prometheus using the .NET SDK.

Resolves [#11227](#).



Using AI agents responsibly

- The level of effort is not symmetric
- AI fatigue is real



Final tips



Final tips

- Follow your interests
- Don't wait to be asked
- Start small
- Prepare for feedback
- Be human
- Have fun!



Questions?



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Questions? 🎤



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